

# AI-Powered Technologies Transform AUTISM CARE AND THERAPY

Technologies like artificial intelligence (AI), virtual reality (VR), robotics, and wearables are beginning to play a significant role in enhancing support and care for individuals with autism spectrum disorder (ASD).



*Nao, the friendly robot, goes to school to help kids with special needs (Source: IEEE Spectrum)*



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Autism is always in the grey—literally—be it for the individual or the caregivers. From diagnosis to degree of intervention, everything feels ambiguous. You may often come across people on the autistic spectrum and not even realise it—many just come across as introverts, perfectionists, or even highly talented geeks, for want of a better term. Because, although they may suffer from social communication challenges, repetitive behaviours and/or restricted interests, many autistic individuals are very talented. They might excel in arts, sciences, math, programming, or even sleuthing. Bill Gates once said that if he had been evaluated in his childhood years, he would most probably have been diagnosed with ASD; and in a TV show, Elon Musk remarked that he was on the autistic spectrum too. Experts now feel that many greats of yesteryears, from Albert Einstein

and Charles Darwin to Vincent van Gogh and Nikola Tesla, appear to have had developmental disabilities like autism. There is a popular inference that author Conan Doyle's famous detective Sherlock Holmes was on the autistic spectrum too!

The point is, many autistic individuals are perfectly capable of using their strengths and abilities to accomplish amazing things and achieve great success and fame in life. If they could do it years ago, without even a proper diagnosis, it is definitely possible today with greater awareness, better diagnosis and detection, and personalised care and support.

## From early detection to individualised intervention

Due to its broad spectrum and often indirect symptoms, it is extremely difficult to diagnose ASD. This sometimes